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Senate GOP takes aim at Fauci

Scientists rush to epidemiologist's defense ahead of unusual hearing rehashing pandemic response

By Lauran Neergaard and Ali Swenson
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — Dr. Anthony Fauci on Wednesday repeatedly invoked the Fifth Amendment and declined to answer dozens of questions from senators in a Republican-led committee hearing about his handling of the COVID-19 pandemic.

The decision, at least for now, shielded Fauci from answering questions that could expose him to accusations of lying under oath. Though he received a pardon in early 2025 from Democratic President Joe Biden, some Republicans pursuing a yearslong campaign for his arrest had suggested he could still face charges for any perjury committed during Wednesday's hearing.

The scientist, who helped lead the nation's COVID-19 response, was subpoenaed to testify under oath by Republican Sen. Rand Paul of Kentucky, who has long had an antagonistic relationship with Fauci. In response to angry, sometimes mocking, questions from Republican senators, Fauci declined to answer more than 100 times, injecting new drama into partisan divides that have festered for years about the origins and handling of the pandemic.

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Dr. Anthony Fauci, who helped lead the nation's COVID-19 response, appears before the Senate Homeland Security and Governmental Affairs Committee on Wednesday in Washington. **ALLISON ROBERT/AP**

LOLLAPALOOZA



ARTHUR MAIORELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Half pipe, full volume

Dave Bachinsky, a professional skateboarder working for Kona Big Wave, catches some air as the Chicago skyline can be seen while he tests Kona's skate ramp on Wednesday, one day before Lollapalooza opens. The four-day music festival is expected to bring 460,000 people to Grant Park to watch performances by Charli xcx, Lorde, Smashing Pumpkins and others.

FESTIVAL BRINGS INCREASED PATROLS

Scores of extra Chicago police officers will be deployed throughout downtown over Lollapalooza weekend. **Page A2**

RAIN THREATENS ON FRIDAY, SATURDAY

Lollapalooza attendees will enjoy mild temperatures, but showers and storms could roll in after the first day. **Page A2**

CHICAGO PUBLIC SCHOOLS

Welch to lobby for more funding

Embattled speaker moves to shore up progressive support

By Jeremy Gornier and Kate Armanini
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Illinois House Speaker Emanuel "Chris" Welch, facing mounting questions within his own Democratic caucus over how his office handled sexual harassment allegations against a now-former lawmaker, moved Wednesday to shore up support with a key progressive ally — telling Chicago Teachers Union members he'll push for additional state funding for Chicago Public Schools during the fall veto session as the district confronts a massive budget hole and the threat of hundreds of teacher layoffs.

"I strongly committed in the veto session to supporting the supplemental funding bill because I know we're all going to be there (in Springfield) for veto session," Welch told CTU members at an Illinois Federation of Teachers board meeting, according to

See **WELCH** on Page A4

■ Milwaukee makes a bid for laid-off CPS teachers. **Page A3**

ICE again detains man once released to donate kidney to his brother

By Laura Rodríguez Presa
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Jose Gregorio Gonzalez, a Venezuelan migrant who was temporarily released from ICE detention last year so he could donate a kidney to his dying brother, has once again been detained by immigration authorities in Chicago.

Gonzalez was arrested July 21 during a routine ICE check-in while his attorney was seeking to extend his humanitarian parole, which would have allowed him to remain in the country for another year as he and his brother continued recovering from the lifesaving transplant.

"At least until the two of us are healthy enough to recover from the transplant," said Alfredo

Pacheco, Gonzalez's youngest brother and the one who received the kidney. Since the transplant in August of last year, Pacheco has had several complications from the procedure and has relied on his brother to care for him, he said.

After a public campaign last year that drew national attention, ICE granted Gonzalez a humanitarian parole of one year, which expired in March. He remained in the country under an order of supervision, regularly checking in with immigration officials while his attorney, Peter Meinecke, senior staff attorney at The Resurrection Project, sought an extension.

"He wasn't picked up until

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INSIDE



STACEY WESCOTT/
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Ready to move

Bears quarterback Caleb Williams said he lost 10 to 15 pounds over the offseason, aiming to be more agile both inside the pocket and when he breaks loose. **Sports**

■ City's top cop search could be delayed until after mayoral election. **Page A4**

ELECTION 2027 MAYOR

Union jabs Johnson as petitions circulate

Trade workers allege city contract violations; Giannoulas may enter race at Sunday event

By Talia Soglin and A.D. Quig
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

As nominating petitions began circulating for Chicago's upcoming mayoral election this week, another local trade union accused Mayor Brandon Johnson of hypocrisy — highlighting the political fractiousness within the city's powerful labor movement.

"Mayor Johnson's NOT the Working Man's Mayor if you're a member of LiUNA Local 1001," read a fiery Tuesday news release from the local, which represents a small slice of workers across several city departments.

LiUNA Local 1001 business manager Bob Chianelli accused the Johnson-appointed leaders of the departments of Transportation, William Cheaks, and

Aviation, Michael McMurray, of violating the laborers' contracts and treating them "like indentured servants."

"Most of the members of Local 1001 are middle class working men and women with families who go to work every day and just want what's coming to them," Chianelli said. "They don't need to be insulted, degraded and abused by these two rogue Commissioners who think they are Kings and not public servants."

The release came the same day candidates could begin circulating nominating petitions for the 2027 mayoral race. LiUNA's political action committee has donated heavily this year to Secretary of State Alexi Giannoulas, who

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